

25 Questions to Ask Your GI Doctor

This improved patient checklist is designed to help ulcerative colitis patients communicate clearly with their gastroenterologist and prepare for more productive appointments.

Preparing for Your Appointment

- Write down your top symptoms before the visit including bleeding, urgency, bowel frequency, fatigue, abdominal pain, and weight changes.
 - Bring a full medication list including supplements, vitamins, probiotics, and over-the-counter medications.
 - Track symptom patterns over several days because details help your doctor assess disease activity more accurately.
 - Bring previous colonoscopy or lab reports if you changed doctors recently.
-

Questions About Your Symptoms

- Do my symptoms suggest mild, moderate, or severe ulcerative colitis activity?
 - Could infection such as C. difficile or food poisoning be contributing to symptoms?
 - Should stool testing, blood work, or imaging be performed?
 - Should anemia, dehydration, vitamin deficiency, or inflammation markers be checked?
-

Questions About Medications

- Is my current treatment controlling inflammation effectively?
 - Should rectal mesalamine, steroids, biologics, or JAK inhibitors be considered?
 - How quickly should improvement happen after starting a new medication?
 - What side effects and monitoring tests are most important?
-

Long-Term Management

- What does remission look like for my specific disease severity?
 - How often should I have colonoscopy monitoring?
 - What symptoms should send me to the emergency room?
 - Should I consider dietitian support, mental health support, or clinical trials?
-

Quick Reference Summary

Important Topic	Why It Matters
Bleeding	May signal active inflammation or worsening disease
Fatigue	Can indicate anemia, inflammation, or nutritional deficiency
Steroid Dependence	Repeated steroid use may mean stronger maintenance therapy is needed
Urgency	Helps doctors understand flare severity and quality-of-life impact

Medical Disclaimer: This educational resource is not medical advice. Always consult a licensed gastroenterologist before starting, stopping, or changing treatment.